

It didn't take long for the queenside attack to bear fruit. The a-pawn is doomed and with White's pawn already on a6 Black must deliver mate or lose the game.

21...g4 22 Nxa7 g3 23 Nc6 Qd7 24 Bg1

It is much too dangerous to accept the pawn. After 24 hxg3 fxg3 25 Bxg3 h4 followed by ...Nh5 Black has a massive kingside attack. That sort of variation is the cornerstone of Black's strategy.

24...Ng4?

I suspect Black is in a bad way already but she should have tried either 24...h4 or 24...gxh2.

25 fxg4 hxg4 (Diagram 14) 26 Bxg4!

By returning the piece White exchanges queens and forces an ending where the a-pawn is bound to have the final word.

Exercise 2: White would have happened to White if he had played 26 a7?

26...Qxg4 27 Qxg4 Bxg4 28 Nf3 Bxf3 29 Rxf3 Nh4 30 a7

There was still time for White to lose tragically: 30 Rfa3 f3 31 gxf3?? g2 mate. Korchnoi just keeps his rook on f3 to avoid any tricks. The a-pawn is going to collect far more than any exchange he may lose on the kingside.

30...Bg7 31 Ra5 gxh2 32 Bf2 Nxf3 33 gxf3 Kf7 34 Rb5 Bf6 35 Rb7 Kg6 36 b5 Kh6 37 Rb8 Rh8 38 Rxh8+ Bxh8 39 Bh4! Rg8 40 Kxh2
Black resigns

White is going to play Bd8.

Game 17

□ Koutsin ■ Frolov

Kiev 1995

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 Nf3 0-0 6 Be2 e5 7 0-0 Nc6 8 d5 Ne7 9 Ne1 Nd7 10 Be3 f5 11 f3 f4 12 Bf2 g5 13 a4 a5!?

This is an attempt to punish White for his move order. By blocking the queenside with ...a7-a5 and ...b7-b6 Black makes it very difficult for White to achieve his most dangerous queenside advance c4-c5.

14 Nd3 b6

The consistent follow-up. There is no point playing ...a7-a5 if Black just allows White to play c4-c5 afterwards.

15 b4

White must play b2-b4 at some point but there is a school of thought which believes that White should first shore up his kingside defences with 15 Be1 h5 16 Nf2 Nf6 17 h3 and only then play b4. As usual Black will aim for ...g5-g4.

15...axb4 16 Nb5

The immediate 16 Nxb4 is also possible with an unclear position after

16...Nf6 17 Nc6 Nxc6 18 dxc6 Qe8

16...Nf6 17 Be1?!

The plan of taking on b4 with the bishop looks too optimistic. It was still possible to play 17 Nxb4, meeting 17...g4 with 18 Bh4!. Black should probably play one solid move, 17...Bd7, before embarking on his kingside attack.

17...g4 18 Bxb4

Because the knight on b5 no longer protects e4 (as it did from c3) Black was able to play ...g5-g4 without further preamble. After 18 fxe4 Nxe4 Black's central pawns are potentially deadly.

18...g3 19 h3 Bxh3! (Diagram 15)

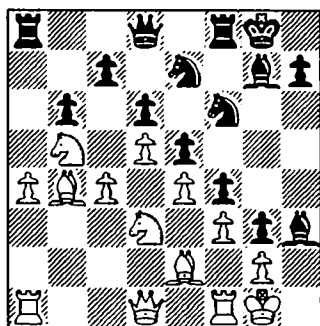


Diagram 15
The thematic sacrifice

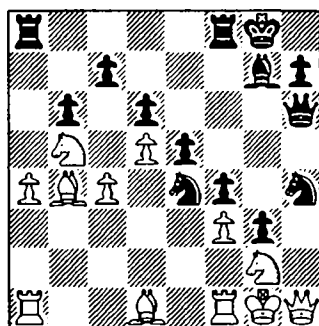


Diagram 16
What now for Black?

This bishop was born to lay down its life on h3. If Black delays then White will reinforce his defences with Re1 and Bf1. There is no reason to delay!

20 gxh3 Qd7 21 Qc2

The only variation that Black needed to calculate before sacrificing is 21 Kg2? Ng6 22 Rh1 Nh4+ 23 Kg1 Nxe4! 24 fxe4 f3 and White gets blown away. He didn't need to look at anything else because if White can't play Kg2 then Black will pick up the crucial pawn on h3.

21...Qxh3 22 Bd1 Ng6 23 Qg2 Qh6! 24 Qh1 Nh4 25 Ne1

If White can play just one more move, 26 Ng2, then he can beat off the attack. It's time for another sacrifice to keep up the momentum.

25...Nxe4!

For those of you who have been checking the variations in the notes this can come as no surprise.

26 Ng2! (Diagram 16)

26 fxe4 f3 is completely hopeless for White.

26...Rf5?!

Black had another fascinating possibility: 26...Nxf3+! 27 Bxf3 Qxh1+ 28 Kxh1 Nf2+ 29 Rxf2 gxf2 30 Rf1 (there is nothing better, e.g. 30 Be4 Rxa4!) 30...Rxa4 31 Ba3 Rxc4 32 Rxf2 and the rook and five pawns should beat the three minor pieces. This looks more convincing than Black's choice in the game.

27 fxe4 f3 28 Bxf3 Nxf3+ 29 Rxf3 Qxh1+ 30 Kxh1 Rxf3 31 Kg1!

Not falling for 31 Nxc7 Rxa4! 32 Rxa4 Rf1 mate.

31...Rb3?

Black needed one careful defensive move to keep the advantage. After 31...Bf8 32 Nxc7 Rc8 it is important that the d6-pawn is defended.

32 Nxc7! Rf8 33 Be1?! Bf6! 34 Nb5 Be7 35 Ra3 Rxa3 36 Nxa3 Rf3 37 Nc2 Bg5 38 Bb4 h5 39 Nce1 Rf6 40 a5 bxa5 41 Bxa5 Rf2 42 Bc7 Be7 43 Ne3 Re2 44 N1g2 Ra2 45 c5 Ra1+ 46 Nf1 h4 47 Nxh4 Bxh4 48 Bxd6 Re1 49 c6 Rxe4 50 c7 Rc4 51 Bxe5 Kf7 52 N1g3 Bxg3 Draw agreed

Game 18

□ Borges Mateos ■ Pecorelli

Cali 2000

1 d4 Nf6 2 Nf3 g6 3 c4 Bg7 4 Nc3 0-0 5 e4 d6 6 Be2 e5 7 0-0 Nc6 8 d5 Ne7 9 Ne1 Nd7 10 Be3 f5 11 f3 f4 12 Bf2 g5 13 Rc1 Rf6!

In practice the most common reply to 13 Rc1 is 13...Ng6 but then Kozul's pawn sacrifice 14 c5!? Nxc5 (14...dxc5 is worse) 15 b4 Na6 leaves Black on the defensive. 13...Rf6 is certainly more fun to play. The basic idea is to play ...Rh6 and ...Qe8 and if White fails to take the necessary defensive precautions then Black plays ...Qh5 and mates him.

14 Nd3 Rh6 (Diagram 17)

Before we see White getting crushed a few times I shall just outline his main defensive strategies:

1) White can play Kh1 in order to meet ...Qh5 with Bg1. Black would then love to land a knight on g3 but more often he ends up playing for ...g5-g4.

2) White can play Be1 and Nd3-f2 so that he can meet ...Qh5 with h2-h3. Assuming that White arrives in time (i.e. he is not going to get blown away by a sacrifice on h3) then Black should switch strategies and play ...Rg6 (without ...Qh5), ...h7-h5 and ...g5-g4. This, for example, is the way the no-nonsense American Grandmaster Yermolinsky plays with White (15 Be1!).

3) White can play g2-g4. In practice this tends to occur out of desperation when it is already too late, but if White played it on move 14, for example, it would be quite acceptable.

Now my conscience is clear (I've told White how to defend) we can return to the main theme of the day which is checkmating White in double quick time.

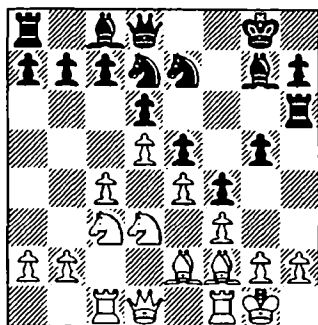


Diagram 17
How might White defend?

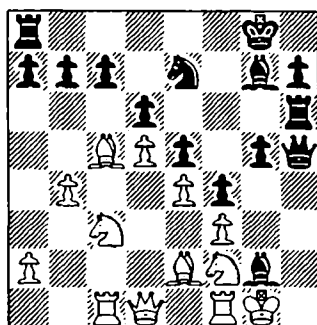


Diagram 18
Black piles his way through

15 b4 Qe8 16 c5?

16 Kh1 was necessary.

16...Qh5 17 h3 Nxc5!

The prosaic 17... Nf6 also does the trick. White can't stop the devastating sacrifice on h3.

18 Bxc5 Bxh3! 19 Nf2 Bxg2! (Diagram 18) 20 Ng4 Qh1+ 21 Kf2 Qh4+ 22 Kg1 Rh5 White resigns

White could have played on a little with 23 Qe1 (only move to stop ...Qg3) but after 23...Qh3 Black will soon be winning on material, if nothing else, as White can't save the bishop on c5 or the rook on f1.

Game 19

□ Opalic ■ Socko

Passau 1999

1 d4 Nf6 2 Nf3 g6 3 c4 Bg7 4 Nc3 0-0 5 e4 d6 6 Be2 e5 7 0-0 Nc6 8 d5 Ne7 9 Ne1 Nd7 10 Be3 f5 11 f3 f4 12 Bf2 g5 13 Rc1 Rf6! 14 b4 Rh6 15 c5 (Diagram 19) 15...a6

This has been played on several occasions to prevent Nb5 but I don't see the need for it. For example, after 15...Qe8! 16 Nb5 Qh5 White's only move to stop mate is 17 h4 (17 h3 Bxh3) but Black still gets a very strong attack with 17...gxh4 followed by ...h4-h3. Who cares about the queenside!

Instead of 16 Nb5 White can play 16 Kh1 and now Black should play 16...Nf6! and after 17 Nb5? (17 Nd3 is better) 17...Qh5 18 Bg1 (Diagram 19)

Exercise 3: White threatens Nxc7 and appears to have stopped all the threats on the kingside with his last move 18 Bg1. What should Black play? Very difficult, but this contains a key idea in this sort of attack. As a hint take note of the '!' that I gave to Black's 16th move.

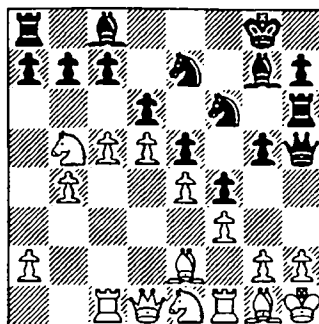


Diagram 19

What should Black play?

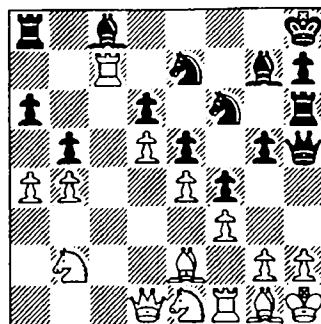


Diagram 20

What this time for Black?

16 Na4

The idea of this move is to keep the knight on d7 tied down as if it moves White can exchange on d6 and then play Nb6.

16...Qe8 17 Kh1 Kh8!? 18 cxd6 cxd6 19 Rc7 b5 20 Nb2 Nf6 21 a4 Qh5 22 Bg1 (Diagram 20) 22...Nfxd5! 23 Rxc8+

White removes the bishop as after 23 exd5 Nf5! 24 h3 Ng3+ 25 Kh2 it would have sacrificed itself on h3. Of course this is the same trick as above in a slightly different guise.

23...Rxc8 24 exd5 Nf5 25 h3 e4 26 Kh2 e3 27 Ned3 Nh4 White resigns

Black's next move is ...Nxg2. White should have played the prophylactic Bg1 at some point (move 18, for example).

Summary

- 1) This chapter is very heavily theoretical but there are general rules and strategies to help you through the maze.
- 2) The lines with 10 Nd3 are not seen quite as often as they used to be and a lot of players have forgotten the theory. I suspect White would score rather well if he studied this line carefully.
- 3) The lines where White blocks the kingside with g2-g4 can be frustrating for Black but if he is patient and builds up his position then something usually turns up. A sacrifice on g4 or an invasion down the h-file are the ideal scenarios.
- 4) The lines with 10 Be3 are often quite thrilling. If you just want to improve your tactical skill, then you could do a lot worse than immersing yourself in these variations. The plan with ...Rf6-h6 can be highly rewarding. I have to admit that the coverage above has been slightly biased in Black's favour but it is a truly dangerous system.